

Longing in Fake Video Games and Conceptualization as a Ludic Activity

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The capacity for interaction is arguably one of the defining features of the medium of video games. As software that runs on digital devices, namely personal computers and game consoles, a video game is able to interpret player input and respond accordingly, continually updating its game state as the player navigates through the game. By doing so, a video game establishes rules and boundaries for how the player can engage with it. However, there exists a genre of media which adopts the various trappings of video games, but lacks any response to the player input, instead compelling the “player” to imagine what these systems would be like in practice. This is the genre of so-called “fake” video games, which, as a preliminary description, broadly refers to video games that don't, and were never originally intended to, exist in fully realized or playable states.

As ostensibly abridged renditions of video games, it may seem as if fake video games have little appeal. However, that is not entirely the case. Though these works set aside one of the main features of video games, fake video games have their own merits. Notably, fake video games are particularly adept at engaging with the “player’s” imagination. By alluding to the existence of a video game that, in truth, does not exist, fake video games evoke a desire for the “game” in question to be real. Spurred by the perceived incompleteness of the game, the “player” is obliged to imagine what the game would be like in practice, reconstructing it within their imagination, using provided context alongside their own background knowledge on video games. At the same time, the player also conceives of the broader world in which the video game itself inhabits. Though the “player” does not receive any feedback, this imaginative process is in and of itself a playful activity.

To understand the specifics by which this process is achieved, a more formal definition for fake games must first be established. The particular details of what constitutes a “fake” game are contentious. There already exist several possible definitions in academic literature, but they often conflict with one another or otherwise distinguish between several subtly different, but closely related, phenomena (fake, fictional, and non-actual games). As a baseline, the term “non-actual game” will hereby refer to any “game” that does not exist in a fully playable state. Fake games will then refer to a specific subcategory of non-actual games. The definition for fake games will mostly follow from an existing definition for “fictional” games. Fictional games are defined as “playful activities and ludic artefacts that were conceptualised to be part of fictional worlds. These games cannot – or at least were not originally meant to – be actually played” (Gualeni 187). This definition is very versatile. The description as “playful activities and ludic artefacts” is very inclusive of the many ways a fake game can present itself. On the other hand, specifying these works must not be made with the intent of being playable helps distinguish fake games from potential edge cases that may at first appear like fake video games, such as scam games and unfinished games.

However, this definition only accounts for games that exist inside another fictional piece of media (i.e. *Dejarik* or *Holochess* in *Star Wars*), and excludes these “playful activities and ludic artefacts” that exist outside of any parent work of fiction. This definition is insufficient for fake games, as many fake games exist independently of any parent media. This definition for fictional games can be modified to one for fake games by explaining that a non-actual game can “create a fictional world around [itself]” (Timvig). This is to say, a non-actual game need not exist within a fictional world, instead, it itself generates the fictional world within the “player’s” imagination. Thus, same as fictional games, the definition for fake games going forward will be

that of “playful activities and ludic artefacts” that are not possible to, or at least not originally intended to, be played, with the caveat that that “player” will imagine a world in which this game exists. This process of imagining such a world is the main appeal of fake video games, and a ludic process in its own right, as it turns out.

To demonstrate, it helps to examine existing fake video games. The most popular fake video game, and consequently the most representative of the genre, is a title by the name of *Vermis*. *Vermis: Lost Dungeons and Forbidden Woods*, by internet artist Plastiboo, is an artbook in the format of a game guide to a game that doesn’t exist. The book features a retro pixel art style, and contains detailed descriptions of various speculative mechanics, such as playable characters, environments, encounters, creatures, status effects, and items. Plastiboo takes heavy inspiration from classic dungeon crawlers and dark fantasy games, specifically citing *The Immortal*, *King's Field*, *Dark Souls* and *Light Crusader* (Martino, translated from original Italian). Interestingly, the book styles itself as an “official” game guide despite entirely lacking a primary source material. While the guidebook itself exists, it is missing the game it is supposedly a guidebook for, referencing it as if it really exists.

By presenting the mechanics and other context of *Vermis* as if it were a real game, the guidebook evokes a “longing” for it to be a real game. This sense of longing is very similar to one achieved by real video games through supplementary materials. Video games can often evoke a feeling of reflective nostalgia. As opposed to restorative nostalgia, which attempts to recreate or recover a lost past, reflective nostalgia is about longing for a place that can never truly be inhabited (Goetz 60-61). Players do not necessarily long for a historical past, but rather for imaginary places that they have never visited and never can. Thus, video games can create a

persistent sense of unfulfilled desire, or a wish to travel to an "elsewhere" that always remains just out of reach.

One of the key methods by which this reflective nostalgia is created is through the use of supplementary materials, namely video game paraphernalia such as “instruction manuals, box and cartridge art, news and strategy magazines, monographic guidebooks, television commercials, and merchandise.” These accompaniments “nostalgically sustain the game by evoking a paratextual process extending beyond the confines of the software system.” This phenomenon was especially common in games of the past, as “given sharp limitations to software memory [...], games programmed in the 1970s, 80s, and 90s,” like those that inspired *Vermis*, “relied on such objects to flesh out core visual, instructional, and narrative details.” (Goetz 66-67). These materials enlarge the world of the video game. They sustain the fantasy of exploration even when the game is turned off, preserving the sense that there is always more to discover. In previous decades, when video games were more restricted by technical limitations, these supplementary works were critical to preserving the facade of a grander world. In turn, however, when faced with the actual finite, and sometimes quite constrained, world of the video game, a certain dissatisfaction can arise.

Fake video games also operate by a similar process, only taken to an extreme. Since they completely lack a primary source material, fake video games don't just sustain the illusion of there being more, but actively encourage the player to imagine what it would be like if these fake games were real. They first create a feeling of longing, same as other video game materials. Through this longing, in conjunction with lacking a primary source material, the “player” is obliged to conceptualize the game. Within the context of *Vermis*, the fake game “presents the reader with an ontological gap which the reader is invited to fill in. *Vermis*, thus, functions like [a

tool] in that it invites the reader to play that they are playing a game” (Timvig 12). This imaginative process is the main way that fake games achieve fun. “Since there is no order in *Vermis*, and since the reader (upon signing the reader’s contract by engaging with the guidebook) enters a ludic session where the lack of gameplay offers a limitless set of possibilities wherein only one’s imagination sets the boundaries, reading *Vermis* as a guidebook might be conceived as a literary form of play, wherein the reader engages in a game of worldbuilding by the help of the guidebook” (Timvig 7). This process can also be taken as a style of roleplaying, since the reader pretends, for a time, that the game is real, and even that they are playing it.

Another example of a fake video game is *Apple Quest Monsters*, by artist Samanthuel Louise Gilson, known as Splendidland online. *Apple Quest Monsters* takes the form of a game manual for a nonexistent monster battler in the vein of *Pokémon*. The original version was released in 2017, and a deluxe edition was released in 2018. The most notable aspect of this game is its creative origins. This fake video game was inspired by Gilson's childhood in which she would read manuals of games she had never actually played before. Gilson sought to deliberately recreate the same feeling she had reading manuals. This is especially interesting, as this work showcases the power that supplementary materials have to evoke longing. To Gilson, reading game manuals was the way by which she engaged with these video games and perceived their worlds. Pulling from her own experiences, Gilson purposefully leveraged this phenomena and applied it to a game that does not exist. To Gilson, the video games that these manuals belonged to might as well have been fake video games. Same as Gilson in the past, the reader is invited to imagine what these games would look like.

However, these two examples only scratch the surface of the many forms fake video games can take. Though *Vermis* and *Apple Quest Monsters* differ greatly from one another, the

two fake video games share a similar format as supplementary information books to their respective nonexistent games. At the implication of the existence of an entire game, the player is invited to reconstruct the game from disparate fragments. Again, this is not a process entirely unique to fake video games. Many real video games, especially those from previous decades, also use game manuals, guide books, and other supplementary materials to expand the game's world beyond the screen and sustain the idea that there is always more content to be found. Fake video games merely enhance this process. However, fake video games increase the number of ways by which this process can happen. Since the fake video game does not exist at all, it can be said that *any* material, so long as it suggests the existence of a video game, activates this process. A fake video game need not be restricted to the format of supplementary materials.

Take for instance the *Bird World*, created by musician Leon Chang, known as Leyawn online. *Bird World* is a music album that styles itself as an original soundtrack to a game that doesn't exist. While it *is* accompanied by an illustrated manual, featuring character profiles, locations, and some information on game mechanics, it is rather short and simple. The main focus is the music. Chang was specifically inspired by music from retro console RPGs like those of the SNES. This example is noteworthy for not being a supplementary work to a would-be game, like *Vermis* and *Apple Quest Monsters*. Instead, the various songs would be assets that would be found directly within the game, if it were real. In a real game, the music would be part of the holistic experience of playing the video game. In the case of *Bird World*, the music is really the only material from the game to exist. Thus, its isolated existence, which implies the rest of the game, sustains the feeling that there is more content to discover, similar to how a game guide expands the world of a real game.

Though restorative nostalgia is not the ultimate goal of fake video games, it is notable that many fake video games pay homage to games of the past, and, in doing so, loosely placing these conceptualized video games in a specific time and/or place. Again, *Vermis* takes inspiration from older dark fantasy games and retro dungeon crawlers. The format of *Vermis* in and of itself harkens back to a time before the mass proliferation of the internet, when game guides were more ubiquitous in gaming (Martino, translated from original Italian). Similarly, *Apple Quest Monsters* follows in the steps of classic monster battlers like *Pokémon*. It harkens back to a time of solely physical releases, where game manuals came included along with cases. On the other hand, *Bird World* directly pays homage to music from retro console video games, even using sounds from these systems. Leon Chang specifically cites the music of *Super Mario RPG*, *Street Fighter II*, *Final Fantasy VII* as inspiration, as well as Japanese video game composers of this time, such as Koji Kondo, Hiroshi Kawaguchi, and Yoko Shimomura (Jenkins). By evoking these video games of the past, the imaginative process that the “player” engages in becomes twofold. Not only is the player reconstructing the video game in their head, they are also placing that video game in a particular time and place of the past. Thus, a fake video game “evokes not only a world that doesn't exist,” that of the game itself, “but also a world that no longer exists,” that of the time and place in which the game would have been released (Martino, translated from original Italian).

In truth, however, these fake video games actually evoke worlds that *never* existed. A fake video game may bring to mind a particular time and place from the past, but the player must nonetheless imagine what it would be like to retroactively fit the conceived video game, along with its surrounding context, into said past. Unless specifically laid-out by the work, any details on the video game’s history, community, reception, and technical aspects can only be imagined.

For example, the story of *Vermis* is so esoteric that one must ask what its critical reception would be if it existed, or how such a game could ever be published in the first place. Though inspired by retro consoles, it cannot be said on which specific system *Bird World* is played on, or even if the game is played on a real system at all, and so the player is left to come to their own conclusions on the matter. It can also be mentioned that *Bird World* has a sequel album titled *Return to Bird World*, which implies an entire unknown development history. It should also be considered that the “player” might not have lived through the time and place the fake video games alludes to, in which case, it truly is a world that never existed, at least for the specific player. Nonetheless, the player may still be inclined to imagine that time and place, despite the lack firsthand experience of what it was like. In any case, a fake game need not evoke a particular time and place, but can instead imply a broader world through other means. Thus, the longing remains simply for a place that doesn’t exist, instead of for a specific historical past. Similar to the act of conceiving of the game itself, imagining the surrounding world can also be taken as a form of worldbuilding and roleplay, as the player imagines themselves existing in this world and having played the game.

Whether in the cases of imagining the game itself or the secondary world in which it resides, the freeform structure of fake video games allows for unconstrained imagination. Many creators themselves cite the genre's open-endedness and utility as a primary appeal. When commenting on the format of *Vermis*, Plastiboo recalls that “[they] immediately thought it was the perfect format for [them],” expressing that “[they] love drawing [...] characters, objects, and situations, without narrative continuity or a focus on any specific story” (Martino, translated from original Italian). Samanthuel Louise Gilson shares a similarly relaxed approach when creating *Apple Quest Monsters*, recalling that she “never put much thought into a battle system,”

and also decided against including a monster type/weakness system as it would “not be terribly fun to read.” Overall, she stresses that the work is only made with only the broad concept of “world with monsters in it” and that she’s “not really someone who thinks a lot about world building” (Maas). Interestingly, Leon Chang specifically cites freedom from technical limitation, explaining that while “[he] definitely [drew] upon a lot of different games from [his] past,” whose systems limited the variety of music that could be played, it was important to him to include “all kinds of elements” in the album to reflect the fact that video games can play any music today (Jenkins). Overall, there is an emphasis placed on the genre's capacity for open-endedness and freedom from limitations. By not overtly concerning themselves with comprehensive explanations or real world practicability, fake video games allow the “player” to conceive of the video game however they wish, leading to highly individualistic experience between players.

Since the genre of fake video games is rather inclusive of many formats and mediums, there arise a number of potential edge cases that border on the line between real and fake video games. Fortunately, several of these scenarios can be explained. This can be done by demonstrating how these nonactual games fall short of achieving the imaginative process of fake games, with these shortcomings only furthering demonstrating the specific goals that fake video games seek to accomplish.

The first such edge case is what can be referred to as “darkly” designed games. From an existing definition, these works involve deceptive, and often malicious or predatory, practices, such as misleading advertisement, scams, or unfinished games, often incentivised by profit (Van de Mosselaer 86). These works are distinguished from other fake video games for not being “aesthetically valuable” experiences, as well as for being unethical. However, “darkly” designed

games aren't actually excluded from fake video games in existing definitions. Instead, they are considered to be a specific subcategory. That said, there is the case to be made that these "darkly" designed games should not be considered fake video games at all, as they do not operate by the same mechanisms or achieve the same feats as other "aesthetically valuable" fake games.

A proper example of a fake video game is forthcoming in what it is, while a darkly designed game is not. A fake game makes its own nonexistence clearly evident and encourages the player to conceptualize a world in which it exists. A "darkly" designed game gives the false promise of a real game. In doing so, the player falls under the illusion that the existence of these games is a foregone conclusion, if not a current reality. It is the difference between suspension of disbelief and a lie. Convinced of the existence of these games, the desire to play and experience one of these games can more aptly be described as excitement or anticipation for a future release instead of longing. A player may still be inclined to imagine what the game in question is like, but this is likely to take the form of speculation over free-form conceptualization.

There is also the scenario in which a fake game is made into a real game. It is quite common for a fake video game to inspire fans to create derivative works. Since, "the game does not exist in the primary world, the variety of conceptualisations of the game [...] will naturally constitute a plethora of unofficial games" (Timvig 16). The longing for a real video game often gives rise to fan-made soundtracks, illustrations, lore discussions, and even entire game adaptations. A simple explanation for this is that these fan-made works can be dismissed as unofficial, and thus having no bearing on the nature of the original works. While not necessarily untrue, this explanation may be somewhat reductive. Instead, the creation of these fan games can be interpreted as part of the speculative process of fakes games, with the player conceptualizing

their version of the fake game through the act of creation. While the final product is a real game that can be played and experienced, it is merely a single interpretation of the original fake game.

The more nuanced version of this scenario is in the event the original creators adapt their fake video game into a playable game. It should be reiterated that a fake video game provides a fundamentally different experience than real games, which is strongly corroborated by creators of fake video games. On the topic of potentially adapting *Apple Quest Monsters* into a real video game, Gilson explains that "[she] would not want to see it adapted into a game, as [she] made it to capture a very specific feeling" (Maas). She also acknowledged "everyone reading the book will have their own ideas as to what it would be like as something playable, and [she doesn't] think it's [her] place to say what it absolutely would be like" (Maas). Gilson's insight in this matter is interesting, as she suggests that the fake video games and real video games accomplish different goals. She cites this as a reason for not wanting to create a real game, but, conversely, this idea suggests that a fake game and a real game exist apart from one another. However, she also believes that an adaptation would encroach on the individual visions of fans. Realistically, a particular vision officially endorsed by the original creator would discourage fans from conceptualizing their own ideas, or perhaps even consuming the original fake game at all. In the end, the original fake game and the official adaptation would be intrinsically tied together forever.

Though fake video games scrap one of the most fundamental aspects of the medium of video games, that of actual playability and interaction, they nonetheless have their own merits. They build on top of the long established conventions and trappings of video games, and instead ask the "player" to reconstruct a video game in their head from provided information, along with the player's own background knowledge of the video game medium. Through the

omission of details that would otherwise be crucial in a real video game, the genre of fake video games is unbound by the traditional creative and technical limitations of the video games medium, allowing both the creator and “player” to envision a world in which these exist. While they are certainly not video games, they are certainly playful, and one can find enjoyment in them over real video games.

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